

SENATE JOINT RESOLUTION 581

By Akbari

A RESOLUTION to honor the memory of music legend Steve Cropper.

WHEREAS, the members of this General Assembly were greatly saddened to learn of the passing of Rock & Roll Hall of Fame guitarist Steve Cropper, who helped form the "Memphis Soul" sound on Stax Records recordings throughout the 1960s and early 1970s; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Cropper was known for his spare, soulful playing and was the secret ingredient to some of the greatest rock and soul songs ever recorded; he is ranked No. 45 on *Rolling Stone's* list of the 250 Greatest Guitarists of All Time; and

WHEREAS, as the founding guitarist in Stax's house band during the Memphis label's hit-making prime, Steve Cropper played on classics such as Sam & Dave's "Soul Man," Booker T. and The M.G.'s "Green Onions," and Wilson Pickett's "In the Midnight Hour," the last two of which he co-wrote; and

WHEREAS, he also helped pen Otis Redding's platinum-selling No. 1 hit, "(Sittin' On) The Dock of the Bay," which is ranked No. 26 on *Rolling Stone's* list of the 500 Greatest Songs of All Time; Mr. Cropper contributed the track's guitar chords and rhythm and finished work on the song, including mixing, in the aftermath of Mr. Redding's death in December 1967; and

WHEREAS, Steve Cropper was born in Missouri and, as a child, moved to Memphis, where he was exposed to gospel music; as a teenaged guitarist, he co-founded the band the Mar-Keys, the group that recorded the classic instrumental "Last Night" for the newly founded Stax label in 1961, making it one of the first tracks released by the label after it changed its name from Satellite Records to Stax; and

WHEREAS, the Mar-Keys soon became the in-house band for Stax; in addition to backing the artists who recorded at Stax's studio, members of the Mar-Keys themselves were

rebranded as Booker T. & The M.G.'s (fronted by Mar-Keys keyboardist Booker T. Jones) for their own releases; and

WHEREAS, following his legendary, nearly decade-long stint at Stax, Steve Cropper moved to Los Angeles, California, and became a go-to session musician, playing on tracks by artists such as John Lennon (1975's *Rock 'n' Roll*), Ringo Starr, John Prine, Leon Russell, Rod Stewart, and the Blues Brothers, with Mr. Cropper also appearing in the 1980 comedy based on the *Saturday Night Live* duo, in which he revisited his work on Sam & Dave's "Soul Man"; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Cropper was inducted into the Rock & Roll Hall of Fame in 1992 as a member of Booker T. & The M.G.'s; he was also a two-time Grammy Award winner and received the Grammys' lifetime achievement award in 2007; and

WHEREAS, Steve Cropper's impact has been far-reaching, and his legacy will live on through his countless contributions to some of the most important songs of his or any generation—songs that will forever remain part of the American music canon; and

WHEREAS, it is most fitting that the members of this General Assembly should pause to remember the bountiful life of this exceptional music artist and human being; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES CONCURRING, that we honor the memory of Steve Cropper, reflecting on his indelible contributions to American music and in helping form the "Memphis Soul" sound.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.